

Checklist:

Promotions

Understand the promotion system

- ☐ I know how promotions are decided at my company.
- ☐ I know whether the process is informal, lightweight, heavyweight, or committee-based.
- ☐ I know who influences or approves promotion decisions.
- ☐ I understand the expectations for my current and next levels.
- ☐ I know whether my company has a “terminal level” or expected career level.

Confirm next-level performance

- ☐ I am consistently exceeding expectations at my current level.
- ☐ I am already demonstrating work expected at the next level.
- ☐ My impact is visible beyond my immediate tasks.
- ☐ I can explain the business or organizational value of my work.
- ☐ I have examples showing both **what** I delivered and **how** I delivered it.

Build a strong promotion case

- ☐ I have a clear record of major projects, outcomes, and impact.
- ☐ I track weekly, monthly, or quarterly achievements.
- ☐ I have artifacts: design docs, code reviews, postmortems, launch notes, metrics, feedback, or presentations.
- ☐ I can connect my work to revenue, cost savings, reliability, productivity, customer impact, or strategic goals.
- ☐ I have evidence that my work has affected a team-, organizational-, or company-level priority.

Produce, organize, publish

- ☐ I consistently **produce** high-quality work.

- ☐ I **organize** work by improving processes, coordinating groups, or helping teams execute better.
- ☐ I **publish** work by sharing progress, outcomes, learnings, and impact.
- ☐ I make my work visible through 1:1s, docs, demos, meetings, or internal posts.
- ☐ I am not relying only on my manager to make my impact visible.

Get feedback early

- ☐ I have asked my manager where I stand relative to the next level.
- ☐ I have asked what gaps remain before promotion.
- ☐ I have asked peers and senior colleagues for feedback.
- ☐ I have spoken with people who have successfully gone through the process.
- ☐ I have identified common promotion blockers at my company.

Secure manager support

- ☐ My manager understands my promotion goal.
- ☐ My manager agrees that I am on a realistic path.
- ☐ My manager can clearly explain my impact to others.
- ☐ I have an actionable promotion plan with milestones.
- ☐ I keep my manager updated on progress and risks.

Build broader support

- ☐ I have support from peers who understand my impact.
- ☐ I have support from senior engineers, staff engineers, directors, or skip-level leaders where relevant.
- ☐ I help others succeed so they are more likely to support me.
- ☐ I mentor or support people at lower levels.
- ☐ I contribute to work that benefits the broader team, not just myself.

Prepare for the promotion packet

- ☐ I have a self-review or promotion document ready.
- ☐ My manager has enough evidence to write a strong review.
- ☐ I have peer feedback or endorsements if required.
- ☐ I have organized artifacts that support the case.
- ☐ I have prepared well before the promotion cycle begins.

Stay realistic

- ☐ I understand promotion is not guaranteed.
- ☐ I know whether there is business need, headcount, or budget for the next level.
- ☐ I understand that senior-level promotions often have lower approval rates.
- ☐ I am not making promotion my only measure of success.
- ☐ I have a plan for what to do if I am not promoted this cycle.

Long-term career health

- ☐ I am not letting title or level define my self-worth.
- ☐ I am not damaging relationships to advance faster.
- ☐ I am investing in skills and experiences that may pay off later.
- ☐ I am choosing work that broadens my breadth, deepens my depth, and sharpens my judgment.
- ☐ I am building a career that remains meaningful even if promotion takes longer than expected.